Agency Evaluation Study

Information Sheet for Teachers

Investigating Children's Agency when learning with AI

We are a team of researchers at University College London (UCL), working with colleagues at the University of Oxford. We are investigating how young people can stay in charge of their own learning when using AI-based tools.

We are inviting students in your class and you to take part in our research project. This information sheet answers questions you might have; please don't hesitate to contact **Prof. Manolis Mavrikis** if there is anything else you would like to know.

Who is carrying out the research?

Principal Investigator: Professor Manolis Mavrikis, UCL Knowledge Lab, m.mavrikis@ucl.ac.uk

UCL Co-Investigators: Dr. Zaki Pauzi; Dr. Vidminas Vizgirda; Ms Yildiz Uzun; Ms Rahki Nair; Dr Kyrill Potapov

Collaborators (University of Oxford): Dr. Jun Zhao (University of Oxford); Dr. Leslye Dias Duran (University of Oxford); Dr. Isobel Voysey (University of Oxford)

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This project has been reviewed and approved by the UCL IOE Research Ethics Committee *[UCL IOE Research Ethics Committee – reference number to be added on approval]*.

Why is this research being conducted?

The aim of the project is to understand how young people can stay in charge of their own learning when using generative AI. We are studying how an application designed to support personal agency influences the way students make choices, set goals, and act deliberately during self-guided learning. We hope the findings will help design better tools and teaching approaches that support young people's agency in the age of AI. We are also interested in teachers' perspectives on how they observe students' agency while using the application and how the application fits into and after classroom activities.

Why are my students invited to take part?

Your students are invited because they are secondary school students aged 13–17, attending [SCHOOL NAME].

Why am I invited to take part?

You are invited because you teach the class participating in this study and can offer insights into how students engage with the application in your classroom.

What does my students' participation involve?

The study runs over approximately five weeks and combines short questionnaires, everyday use of a learning application. With your permission anyone in the class can use the learning application as part of their learning, framed as a non-assessed activity. A smaller, purposively selected group of volunteers takes part in weekly interviews so that we can follow their experience in depth. The activities are:

Whole class:

- A short participant (demographic) questionnaire.
- A short agency questionnaire at the start and again at the end of the study.
- An introductory orientation session.
- Use of the learning application across the five weeks.

Interview group:

- Weekly semi-structured interviews of around 15–20 minutes (including informal check-ins to confirm they are comfortable continuing).
- A closing semi-structured interview of approximately 20–30 minutes.

With consent and assent interviews are audio-recorded and transcribed so that we can analyse them accurately. Recordings are deleted once the transcript has been checked.

What does my participation involve?

We would like to invite you to take part in an informal interview of around sixty minutes, at the end of the study. This will be open conversations about your experience of the study and your observations of students' use of the application, rather than a fixed set of questions. Interviews will take place in person at school or on Microsoft Teams at a time convenient for you. With your consent, the interview will be audio-recorded and transcribed.

Will anyone know my students and I have been involved?

No, not unless the participant chooses to tell others. All data collected are referred to using a pseudonymous study ID. No identifying personal information appears in research outputs (reports, publications, presentations), and any quotes used are anonymised.

Could there be any problems from taking part?

We do not anticipate any risks beyond those of typical classroom and computer-based learning activities. Some students may find reflecting on their own decision-making unfamiliar; participation is framed as non-assessed, and students may skip any question and stop at any time.

The teacher interview is not an evaluation of your teaching. You may decline any question and stop the interview at any time.

What data will be collected and how will it be protected?

Through the study we will collect the following:

- Consent/assent records (parental consent; student assent; teacher consent).

- Participant details needed to run the study: name, class, school, and a study ID.
- Basic demographics: age, gender (optional), and school year.
- Questionnaire responses (agency measures administered at pre- and post-intervention).
- Application interaction logs: date and time of use, session duration, features accessed, frequency of use, choices made within the app, and brief self-reported reasons for use.
- Audio recordings of both teacher and participant interviews, and the transcripts made from them.
- Teacher details needed to run the study: name, role, school, and contact email. Interaction and questionnaire data are stored on secure UCL systems (UCL OneDrive for Business and UCL-managed servers). Even if a conversation or file is deleted from the chat screen, copies continue to stay in the interaction logs. Interview recordings are stored on UCL OneDrive for Business and transcribed using UCL Microsoft 365 services; once researchers have checked the transcripts for accuracy, the recordings are deleted.

Named Oxford researchers work with us on this study under a Data Sharing Agreement, with UCL as the lead data controller. Some of them will carry out interviews alongside UCL researchers, so they will know the participants they meet. For analysis, they can access interview transcripts, pseudonymised questionnaire responses, field notes and logs in which names have been replaced with a study code.

We use services from Microsoft (UCL OneDrive and Teams), Amazon Web Services (which runs the application and its AI models) and Qualtrics (questionnaires). These companies store or process information on UCL's behalf, under UCL's contracts with them. Also, Amazon's AI service automatically checks any image uploaded to the application. If an image is flagged, it is blocked, and Amazon may review it and report it to the NCMEC or another authority. This is separate from the study's own safeguarding procedures.

Apart from these, we will not share personal information with anyone else.

Anonymised data, consent and withdrawal records will be kept for a minimum of ten years after the end of the project, in line with the UCL research data retention schedule.

After this time, at the latest, the anonymised dataset may be made publicly available. Anonymised data may also be used in follow-up research (subject to ethics approval).

What will happen to the results of the research?

We will write up our findings for publication in conference papers, journal articles, PhD theses, and reports to participating schools. On request, the research team is happy to make the results available to participants (contact the Principal Investigator listed above).

What is expected from me as a teacher?

If you decide to take part, we would like you to sign the attached Consent Form and return it to our research team. Researchers from the team, together with you as the class teacher, will help coordinate the study activities within your teaching. The study is framed as non-assessed and is

designed to fit alongside relevant learning in your class. Taking part in the interviews is optional, and you can support the study without being interviewed.

Students who wish to participate but whose parents have not provided consent may speak to you before the study begins; you would provide them with an Assent Form to sign. They can then join all activities like their peers, but their data will not be analysed in the project. A family's decision about participation will not affect any student academically or their relationship with the school or UCL.

Do my students have to take part?

No. Participation is voluntary for every student and requires parental consent and student assent. Students who do not take part, or whose data are not included, still take part in all learning activities.

Can my students and I withdraw from the study?

Yes. Students (or their parents/carers) can withdraw at any time during the study and up to two weeks after the student's final session, without negative consequences for grades. If a student or parent asks you to withdraw, please email the Principal Investigator with the student's name and their request. Within the withdrawal window we will delete the data collected about them; after the window it is difficult to identify and remove individual data. We will also keep a copy of students' original consent forms and withdrawal requests under UCL retention policy.

You may also withdraw from the interview at any time, without giving a reason. In this case, your interview data will be deleted, and we will keep a copy of your original consent form and withdrawal request under UCL retention policy.

Safeguarding

Student free-text within the application will be screened for content that may indicate risk of harm. Flagged content is reviewed by the study's coordinating team and the Designated Safeguarding Leads, and if an issue is identified, it will be referred to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day, where possible, and the student will be told this is happening. We will agree this route with your school before the study begins. Content flagged but judged not to indicate risk stays in the logs and is excluded from analysis.

Data Protection Notice

UCL is the data controller for the personal data collected through this research. UCL will process personal data for the purpose of the research outlined above. Research is a task that we perform in the public interest. For more information, see the UCL General Research Participant Privacy Notice.

UCL General Research Participant Privacy Notice

If you are concerned about how personal data is being processed, or would like to contact us about your rights, please contact the UCL Data Protection Officer at **data-protection@ucl.ac.uk**.

Complaints

If you have any concerns or complaints about the conduct of this project, you are welcome to contact the UCL IOE Research Ethics Office:

Executive Officer

UCL IOE Research Ethics Office

UCL Institute of Education

University College London

20 Bedford Way

London WC1H 0AL

United Kingdom

Email: ioe.researchethics@ucl.ac.uk

Contact for further information

UCL Principal Investigator

Professor Manolis Mavrikis

Email: **m.mavrikis@ucl.ac.uk**

Thank you very much for taking the time to read this information sheet.